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Good. Here's What Works Instead.



DOES YOUR DOG BARK, LUNGE, AND LOSE IT ON WALKS?

THE 4-WEEK PLAN FOR CALM WALKS

Four weeks from now: walks without the lunging.

A PUBLICATION OF THE INSTITUTE FOR STRATEGIC SURRENDER

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The Reactive Dog Guide

Help for the Dog Who Barks, Lunges, and Loses It on Walks

Published by PetsBuzz / Narristotle

This book is not vet advice. When your dog's health or safety is on the line, your vet is the authority.

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Before We Start

This is the book the puppy book pointed to. If you read chapter nine of Puppy's First 30 Days, you already know the line: biting and jumping are puppy problems, and most of them fade. But some puppies grow into dogs whose problem isn't excitement. It's fear. If your dog barks and lunges at strangers or other dogs, if they hide behind you on walks, if their body goes stiff and their hackles go up when something new appears, that's not the puppy stuff. That's fear, and fear grows if you leave it alone.

This guide picks up exactly where that chapter left off.

Three things to know up front. First, your dog is not a bad dog, and nothing in this book treats them like an enemy to be beaten. A reactive dog is usually a scared dog, or a frustrated dog, and sometimes both at once. Second, there is no quick fix here. No weekend cure, no single trick, no gadget that does the work for you. What there is: management first, then training, in that order, at a pace your dog can actually handle. Third, nothing here is vet advice. When your dog's health or safety is on the line, your vet is the authority, and chapter nine tells you exactly when to call.

Each chapter ends with a short "do this today" list, the same as the puppy book. If you only have five minutes, read that and do it. The appendix at the back holds the threshold log and the weekly training-plan template. Photocopy them. You'll want a fresh one every week.

One more thing. If your dog has already bitten someone, or you feel unsafe walking your own dog, skip to chapter nine right now and make the call first. The rest of this book will still be here when you get back, and it works better with a professional in your corner.

Let's get into it.

Chapter 1: Is Your Dog Reactive?

The short answer is yes, if your dog overreacts to things other dogs walk past. Barking, lunging, growling, spinning at the end of the leash, hiding behind your legs, or going stiff and staring like a statue. That's reactivity. It's a behavior with a cause, not a personality trait, and the cause is usually one of two things.

Fear. This is the most common cause, and it's the one people miss, because a scared dog doesn't always look scared. A scared dog can look furious. Barking and lunging at another dog is often a scared dog saying "stay away from me" in the only language they have. The giveaway is what the dog wants: distance. Given a free choice, a fearful dog moves away from the trigger. Their body goes low, their tail tucks, their ears flatten, and if the leash let them, they'd leave. The leash doesn't let them, so they shout instead.

Frustration. The other cause is the opposite. The dog wants to get to the thing, and the leash won't let them. This is the dog who pulls toward every other dog on the walk, whines, barks, and lunges forward, then plays fine off leash at the park. That dog isn't scared. They're frustrated. They want to say hello and the leash says no, so the wanting turns into a scene. People call this dog "dog aggressive" all the time, and most of the time they're wrong. A frustrated greeter is rude, not dangerous, but the barking looks the same from the sidewalk, so everyone treats it the same.

A lot of dogs are a mix of both. Fear of strangers, frustration with other dogs. Fear on a narrow street, frustration in an open park. You don't need a perfect label before you start. You need to watch what your dog does and what they seem to want, because the fix is different: a fearful dog needs to feel safe, and a frustrated dog needs to learn patience. Chapters two through five cover both.

Fear or frustration? A quick test. You don't need a behaviorist to sort this out. You need two walks. The first is your normal walk, on leash, and you watch what happens when a trigger appears. The second is off leash in a safe, fenced place, with a calm dog you know, and you watch what happens there. Only do the off-leash part if you're sure it's safe: a fenced place, a calm dog you know, and a dog of yours who has never bitten. If you're not sure, skip it. The body on a walk tells you the same thing. If your dog is a terror on leash and a polite player off leash, that's frustration. The leash is the problem, not the other dog. If your dog is scared off leash too, hiding behind you or snapping when a dog gets close, that's fear. The leash didn't cause it. The leash just made it louder. The body tells you the same thing on a walk. A fearful dog gets low and tries to move away. A frustrated dog gets tall and pulls toward. Watch the body, not the noise. The noise is the same either way.

Most owners find the answer in one walk, once they know what to look for. Write it down next to the trigger list. Fear or frustration, or a bit of both. That word shapes the work in chapter four, because a fearful dog needs the distance to be bigger and the pace to be slower than a frustrated dog does.

What reactivity is not. It is not dominance. Your dog is not trying to be the boss of you, the street, or the other dog. The dominance idea comes from old studies of captive wolves, and it has been walked back by the same scientists who wrote it. The puppy book said it too: if a trainer tells you to dominate your puppy or alpha-roll them, walk out. That advice is wrong, and for a reactive dog it's worse than wrong, because it adds fear to a dog who is already scared.

It is not spite. Your dog is not embarrassing you on purpose. They are not holding a grudge about the bath. Dogs live in the moment, and a reaction is a moment.

It is not stubbornness. A dog who won't listen when they're over threshold is not being stubborn. They can't listen. The thinking part of the brain goes offline when the fear part takes over. Yelling at a dog in that state is like yelling at someone in the middle of a panic attack. It doesn't help and it makes the next one worse.

Reactivity is not the same as aggression. This matters, so let's be clear about it. A reactive dog overreacts to triggers. An aggressive dog intends to cause harm. Most reactive dogs have never hurt anyone and never will. But a reactive dog who is pushed too far, too often, can learn that the only way to make the scary thing go away is to bite. That's the line this book is trying to keep you on the right side of. If your dog has already bitten, or tried to bite, that's not a training chapter problem. That's a chapter nine problem. Call a professional today.

How bad is it, really? Owners always ask this, and they're really asking whether their dog is normal. Here's the honest answer: reactivity is common. Trainers see it every day. Dogs who bark and lunge on leash are one of the most common reasons people call a trainer, and most of those dogs get a lot better with the work in this book. Your dog is not broken. Your dog is not the worst case anyone has ever seen. Your dog is a normal dog with a problem that has a fix, and the fix takes weeks, not days.

DO THIS TODAY

Write down your dog's triggers. Dogs? People? Bikes? All three? Write down where it happens and how close the trigger was when it started. That's your baseline, and you'll compare everything to it later. Don't skip this. A month from now, when you're not sure if anything is working, that piece of paper will tell you the truth.

Chapter 2: Threshold, the One Idea That Changes Everything

If you take one idea from this book, take this one. Threshold is the line where your dog can still think. Below it, your dog notices the trigger and stays calm enough to learn. Above it, your dog is reacting, and no learning happens at all. Every chapter after this one is about staying below that line.

What threshold looks like. Picture two dogs on the same street. At a hundred feet, your dog sees the other dog, ears go up, body goes a little stiff, and they take a treat from your hand. That's below threshold. At fifty feet, your dog stares hard, won't take the treat, and the leash starts to go tight. That's at threshold. At twenty feet, your dog is barking and lunging. That's over it. The numbers are different for every dog. For some dogs the line is a block away. For others it's across the park. The distance doesn't matter. The line does.

Good days and bad days. Your dog will have both, and the line moves with them. Threshold isn't just distance. It's distance plus everything else going on that day. A dog who handled a stranger at thirty feet on a quiet Tuesday might lose it at sixty feet on Thursday, because Thursday had a garbage truck, a skateboard, and a dog barking behind a fence before you even got to the stranger. Trainers call this trigger stacking: stress adds up, and a dog who reacted at noon is closer to the edge at three o'clock. That's why the log matters. When you see a bad day in the log, look at what came before it. The pattern is usually there. And when you see a good day, write down what was different. Quieter street, earlier hour, a longer sniff walk first. Good days have causes too, and once you know them, you can make more of them. A dog who had a bad morning needs a quiet afternoon.

Stress hormones take a while to clear. When your dog has a big reaction, their body floods with stress hormones, and those take a day or two to come back down. That's why the day after a bad walk is often a bad walk too, even if nothing much happened. The dog isn't being difficult. They're still carrying yesterday. If your dog has a rough reaction, give them a quiet day. Short walk, boring route, no training. Let the hormones clear before you ask them to learn anything.

How to find your dog's line. Go for a walk with a plan. Pick a spot where you can see triggers coming from a long way off, a park edge or a wide street, and watch your dog as the distance closes. The moment your dog notices the trigger and stays soft, that's your starting distance. The moment the body goes stiff, the mouth closes, and the treat gets refused, you've found the edge. Write that distance down. In feet, in blocks, in car lengths, whatever makes sense to you. That's the number the rest of this book works from.

Two warnings. First, don't test the line by walking straight at a trigger until your dog explodes. That's not measuring. That's flooding, and chapter seven explains why it makes things worse. Second, the line moves. On a good day it's closer. On a bad day it's farther. That's normal, and it's why you check it every session instead of trusting last week's number.

The treat test. Here's the fastest way to know where your dog is. Offer a treat. If your dog takes it and eats it, they're under threshold and their brain is still working. If your dog sniffs it and turns away, or takes it and drops it, they're at or over the line. A dog who won't eat is a dog who can't learn right now. That test saves you from guessing, and it works in any situation, on any walk, with any dog.

DO THIS TODAY

Find the distance where your dog notices a trigger and stays calm. Use the treat test to check it. Write the number down in your threshold log at the back of this book. That's the distance you start training from in chapter four.



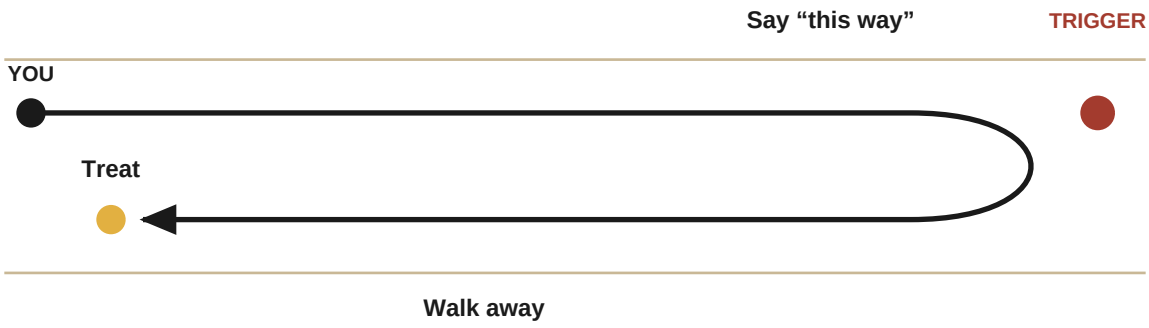
Threshold: below the line, your dog can still think. Above it, no learning happens.

Chapter 3: Management First, Training Second

Everyone wants to skip to the training. Nobody wants to do the management, because management feels like giving up. It isn't. Management is how you stop the problem from getting worse while the training does its work. Every reaction your dog has is practice, and practice makes the reaction stronger. A dog who lunges at ten dogs a week is rehearsing lunging ten times a week. Management cuts that number down, and that alone makes the training easier.

Pick your routes and your hours. Walk when the streets are quiet. Early morning and late evening beat the middle of the afternoon. Pick the wide streets, the ones with sidewalks on both sides and room to cross. Avoid the narrow path where the only way past another dog is three feet away. If your street is full of dogs, drive to a quieter one. That is not cheating. That is management.

The U-turn. This is the most useful skill in this whole book, and it takes a day to teach. At home, in your hallway, say "this way" in a cheerful voice, turn around, and walk the other way. When your dog follows, treat. Do it ten times. Then do it on a quiet street with no triggers around. Then, when you see a dog coming toward you on a walk, you say "this way" before your dog reacts, turn around, and walk away. Your dog learns that the scary thing doesn't have to be faced, and you learn that you always have an exit. Practice it until it's boring. Boring is the point.



The U-turn: say “this way” before your dog reacts, turn, walk away, treat.

Visual barriers are free. A parked car, a hedge, a fence, a mailbox. When you see a trigger coming, step behind something. The dog can't react to what they can't see, and the few seconds behind the car give you time to cross the street or turn around. Owners think this is avoiding the problem. It is. Avoiding the problem is the job right now. Training happens in the sessions you plan. Walks are for management.

No greetings for now. This one is hard, because people love letting their dogs say hello. But on-leash greetings are the worst place for a reactive dog to meet anyone. A leash takes away the dog's ability to walk away, and a dog who can't walk away has only two moves left: freeze or explode. So for now, no on-leash greetings. Not with dogs, not with strangers. Cross the street, turn around, say "sorry, we're training" and keep walking. Your dog will meet other dogs again. Right now they need to learn that other dogs are boring, and boring starts with distance.

When an off-leash dog comes at you. It will happen. Another dog, off leash, running straight at yours. Don't try to manage the other dog. Manage yours. Step behind a car or a hedge if there's one close. Scatter a handful of treats in the grass so your dog's nose goes down. Say "this way" and U-turn away. Keep moving. If the other dog follows, keep walking and don't stop to talk to its owner. Your job is to get your dog out of the situation, not to teach the other dog manners. If it happens a lot on your route, change

the route. That's management too.

Manage the house too. If your dog barks at the window all day, that's ten or twenty reactions before you even leave the house. Block the view. Frosted window film costs a few dollars and sticks to the glass. Close the curtains. Move the dog's bed away from the front window. Every reaction you prevent at home is one less rehearsal, and one less dose of stress hormones for the day.

The car. Some reactive dogs are fine on the street and terrible in the car, barking at every dog they see through the window. The fix is the same as the house: block the view. A crate in the back with a blanket over it, or a shade on the window. If your dog rides in the back seat, a car barrier keeps them out of the front. A dog who can't see the trigger can't react to it, and a calm car ride means a calmer dog when you arrive.

Guests and the front door. The doorbell is a trigger like any other, and most dogs hear it a dozen times a week. Put your dog in another room before you open the door. Let them come out after everyone is seated and the room is calm. If your dog barks at guests for the first five minutes and then settles, that's the pattern to break: the first five minutes. Give them a Kong in the other room, wait until the hellos are over, and then bring them out on leash. Guests who ignore the dog for the first few minutes help more than guests who crouch down and reach for them. Tell your guests that before they arrive. Most people are happy to help once they know the rule. A routine the dog can predict is a routine the dog can relax into.

Kids in the house. Never leave a reactive dog unsupervised with children, not even for a minute. Use the same barriers you use for guests: a baby gate, a closed door, or the crate as a safe room, never as punishment. Teach kids the early signals from Chapter 8: if the dog goes stiff, walks away, or growls, give it space and let it leave.

The walk is not the training session. This is the rule that ties the chapter together. Walks are for management: quiet routes, distance, U-turns, no greetings. Training happens in short, planned sessions where you control the distance and the trigger. When you mix the two up, you get training on a busy street with no plan, and that is how dogs have bad days. Keep them separate. Walk for management. Train on purpose.

DO THIS TODAY

Pick one walk route with escape options, wide streets, and a quiet hour. Walk it once, use one U-turn, and cross the street before any trigger gets close. That's a managed walk, and it counts.

Chapter 4: The Training That Actually Works

Now the training. It's two ideas that work together, and both of them are older than any dog trainer alive. The first is desensitization: show your dog the trigger at a distance where they stay calm, and do it again and again until it gets boring. The second is counter-conditioning: pair the trigger with something good, so the dog's feeling about it changes. Put them together and the dog goes from "that thing is scary" to "that thing means treats," and a dog who expects treats doesn't lunge.

The order matters. Trigger first, then treat. Your dog sees the other dog, and then you give them a treat. Not the other way around. If you hand out treats before the trigger appears, the treats mean nothing. The trigger has to predict the treat. That's what changes the feeling. After a few dozen repetitions, your dog sees the trigger and looks at you, because they've learned that the trigger means something good is coming. That look is the whole game. When your dog looks at you instead of exploding, you're winning.



Trigger first, then treat. The trigger has to predict the treat.

The session, step by step. Pick a spot where you control the distance. A park edge, a wide sidewalk, a parking lot with a clear view. Station yourself at the distance you found in chapter two, the one where your dog notices and stays calm. Wait for a trigger to appear. The moment your dog sees it, say their name or a marker word like "yes," and give them a treat. When the trigger goes away, the treats stop. That's one repetition. Do five or six of them, then go home. Five minutes is a full session. Ten minutes is a long one. Three sessions a week beats one marathon session every time.

Move closer slowly. When your dog is calm at your starting distance for a few sessions in a row, move a few feet closer. Not twenty feet. A few. If the dog reacts at the new distance, you went too far. Go back to the old distance and try again next time. The pace of this work is the dog's pace, not yours. A week at one distance is normal. Two weeks is normal. The dogs who get better fastest are the ones whose owners went slowest, because they never had a bad session to undo.

What a setback looks like. Your dog was doing great at a block away, and today they lost it at a block and a half. That happens. Maybe they had a bad morning. Maybe the trigger was a dog that barked first. Maybe it was just a bad day. Don't panic and don't punish. Add distance, end the session on a win, and go home. Tomorrow is a new session. One bad day doesn't erase a month of good ones. What erases progress is pushing through the bad day and letting the dog practice the reaction five more times.

When there are no triggers around. Some weeks the street is quiet and you can't find a dog to practice with. That's a good problem, and it has a fix: set the session up on purpose. Ask a friend with a calm dog to help. Have them stand at the far end of a field with their dog while you work at your distance. The helper dog doesn't have to do anything. They just have to stand there and be boring. You control the distance by walking closer or farther away, and you end the session when you want to. That's a training session with a volume knob, and it's worth more than ten random encounters on a busy street.

If you don't have a friend with a calm dog, use the triggers you can control. A dog behind a fence, a dog in a car, a dog across the park. The distance is bigger, but the work is the same: trigger appears, treat, trigger goes away, treats stop. What matters is that you chose the distance and you can leave when you want to. A session you control beats a surprise every time.

One more thing about setups. Don't use your neighbor's reactive dog as the helper. Two reactive dogs at a distance is a session with two problems and no margin. The helper dog should be the calmest dog you know, the one who looks at your dog and yawns. Boring is the qualification. Pay your helper back. Bring them coffee, or offer to walk their dog sometime. A good helper dog is worth more than any gadget in this book, and the owner who lends you theirs is doing you a real favor.

A session is five or six repetitions. A week is three sessions. A month is twelve sessions, which is sixty to seventy repetitions, and that's when most owners start to see the change. The number matters because it tells you the work is working even when it doesn't feel like it. Sixty repetitions of trigger-means-treats rewires a feeling. Five repetitions doesn't. That's why the schedule in chapter ten says three sessions a week. It's not a random number. It's the pace that adds up.

The treat matters. Use the good stuff. Not the dry biscuit from the bottom of the bag. Small, soft, smelly treats, the size of a pea, the same kind the puppy book recommended. Zuke's Minis, bits of boiled chicken, little pieces of cheese. Your dog has to want the treat more than they want to react, and on a bad day that takes a really good treat. Cut them small. You're going to use a lot of them, and a dog who fills up on treats stops working for treats.

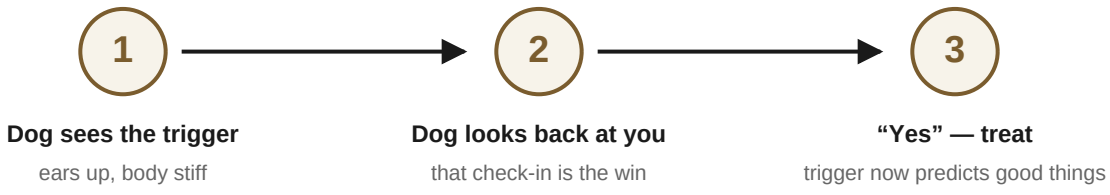
> **DO THIS TODAY**
>
> One five-minute session at the distance where your dog can succeed. Trigger appears, treat, trigger goes away, treats stop. Five or six repetitions, then go home on a win.

Chapter 5: Games That Teach Calm

Training sessions work, but they can feel like work, and dogs know it. Games fix that. A game gives your dog a job to do instead of reacting, and a job they can succeed at. These are the four that matter most. Teach them at home first, where it's easy, and then take them outside.

Look At That. This is the big one. Trainers call it Look At That, and it comes from Leslie McDevitt's Control Unleashed. Here's how it works. Your dog looks at the trigger. You wait for them to look back at you. The second they do, you say "yes" and give them a treat. That's it. You're not asking them to ignore the trigger. You're teaching them that looking at the trigger and then checking in with you is the most rewarding thing they can do. After a while, the dog sees a trigger and turns to you on their own, because that's where the good stuff lives.

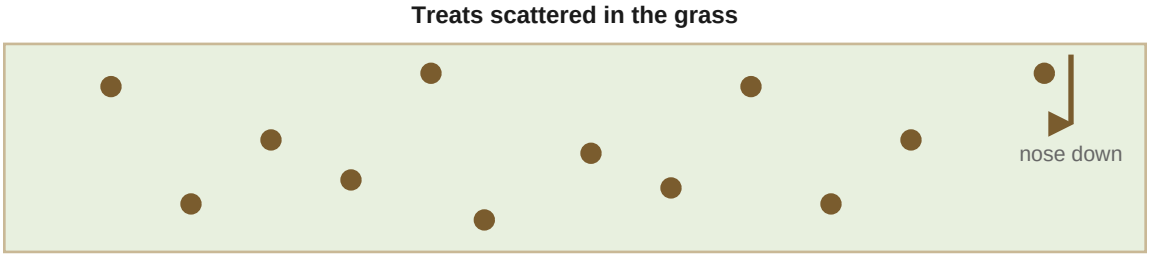
Start at home with something boring. Put a strange object on the floor, a shoe, a bag, anything your dog will look at. When they look at it, wait. When they look back at you, treat. Ten repetitions and they'll get it. Then try it on a walk with a trigger at a safe distance. The first time your dog sees another dog and turns to you instead of lunging, you'll know why this game is in every trainer's toolkit.



Look At That in three steps: see it, check in, get paid.

Say your dog's name, and when they look at you, treat. That's a focus cue, the simplest Look At That. Use it when you need their eyes on you, not the trigger.

Scatter feeding. When a trigger appears at a distance, toss a handful of treats into the grass and let your dog sniff them out. The nose goes down, the body relaxes, and the dog is busy doing something they love instead of staring at the thing that scares them. This works best when the trigger is far away and your dog is already a little tense. Scatter feeding doesn't teach a skill the way Look At That does. It buys you time and calm in the moment, and sometimes that's all you need.



Scatter feeding: toss treats into the grass — nose down buys you calm.

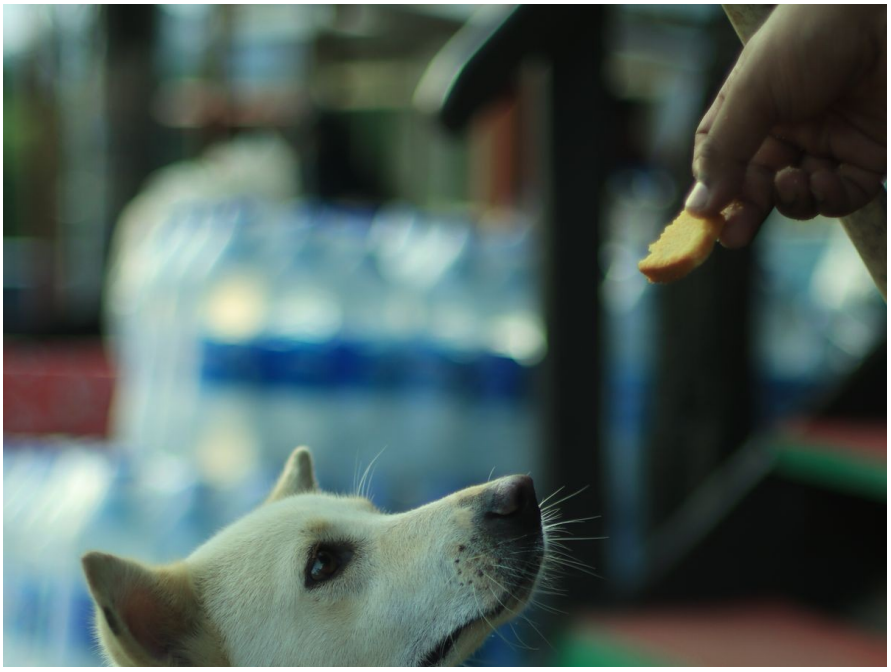
The 1-2-3 game. Count out loud: "one, two, three," and give your dog a treat on three. Do it at home until the pattern is boring. Then use it on walks when you see a trigger coming. The count tells your dog something good is about to happen, and the predictability settles them down. Dogs love patterns. A dog who knows what happens on three doesn't have to guess, and a dog who isn't guessing isn't worrying. This one comes from the same place as Look At That, and it works for the same reason: it gives the dog something to do with their brain besides panic.

The settle mat. A mat is a portable safe spot. A bath mat, a dog bed, any flat thing your dog can lie on. Teach it at home first. Put the mat on the floor, and the second your dog steps on it, treat. Then wait for them to lie down on it, and treat again. Do it ten times a day for a week, and your dog will run to the mat when they see it. Then take the mat to the yard, then to a quiet park bench. When a trigger appears at a distance, send your dog to the mat and feed them treats for staying there. The mat tells your dog where to be and what to do, and a dog with a job doesn't have to invent one.

Use it at outdoor cafes, at the vet's waiting room, at a friend's house. Anywhere your dog needs to be calm and doesn't know how. It's the simplest game in this chapter and the one owners use most, because it works in real life, not just in training sessions. Pick a mat that's easy to carry and easy to wash. A cheap bath mat works better than an expensive dog bed, because you can fold it up and put it in a bag. Wash it once a week. A mat that smells like home works better than a mat that smells like the park.

Games at home for bad-weather days. Some days you can't train outside. Rain, heat, a bad morning. On those days, play search games in the house. Hide treats around a room and let your dog find them. Stuff a Kong with peanut butter and freeze it. Scatter kibble in the grass in the yard. A dog who spent twenty minutes working their nose is a calmer dog, and a calmer dog is a dog who can learn tomorrow. Mental work tires a dog out the same way a long walk does, and on a day when the walk went badly, it's the better choice.

> **DO THIS TODAY**
>
> Teach Look At That at home with a boring object. Ten repetitions. When your dog looks at the object and then looks back at you, say "yes" and treat. That's the whole game, and it's the one you'll use most.



Look At That: the dog sees the trigger — then looks back at you.

Chapter 6: Gear That Helps, and Gear That Hurts

Gear doesn't fix reactivity. Nothing you buy will do the work for you. But the right gear makes the work easier, and the wrong gear makes it harder, sometimes a lot harder. Here's what helps, what hurts, and why.

Front-clip harness. A front-clip harness has the leash ring on the dog's chest instead of their back. When the dog pulls, the clip turns their body sideways, which takes the force out of the lunge. It doesn't stop the reaction. It makes the reaction easier to manage, and it gives you a second to redirect. Fit matters more than brand. Two fingers should fit under every strap, and the harness shouldn't slide sideways when the dog moves. The Easy Walk and the Freedom are the two most trainers recommend, and either one works.

Put it on at home for a few days before you use it on a walk, so the dog gets used to the feeling. Feed them their meals in it for the first few days. Clip the leash on inside the house and walk around the living room. If the dog freezes or tries to bite the straps, go slower and use more treats in shorter sessions. A dog who hates the harness will pull more, not less, and a harness the dog likes is a harness that does its job.

Long line. A long line is a fifteen to thirty foot leash you use in open space, not on a busy street. It gives your dog room to move, sniff, and make choices, which is exactly what a reactive dog needs when there are no triggers around. The point is decompression: a walk where the dog gets to be a dog, on a long line, in a field or an empty park.

Hold it looped around your body, not wrapped around your hand, and wear gloves, because a long line through bare hands burns. Never use it near a road. A dog on a long

line can cover thirty feet in a second, and that's too fast if a car is coming. Practice in an empty field first, with no triggers around, so you learn to handle the line before you need it. Coil the extra length in your hand and let it out a little at a time. If the dog runs to the end of it, don't yank. Let the line go slack and call them back.

Basket muzzle. A muzzle is a safety tool, not a punishment, and for some dogs it's the difference between being able to go out and staying home. If your dog has bitten, or you're worried they might, a basket muzzle lets you train in the world without the risk. The dog can still pant, drink, and take treats through it, which is how you know it's the right kind. The Baskerville Ultra is the one most trainers start with.

Condition it slowly. Day one, smear peanut butter inside the muzzle and let the dog lick it out. Day two, same thing, a little longer. Day three, hold the straps for a few seconds while they eat. By the end of the week, the dog is putting their nose in on their own. Never force it on. Never use it as a punishment. A dog who hates the muzzle is a dog who is more stressed, not less, and more stress is the last thing you need.

What hurts. Choke chains, prong collars, and shock collars all work the same way: they add pain or fear to a dog who is already scared. The dog lunges, the collar hurts, and the dog learns that the other dog causes pain. The reactivity gets worse, not better, and now the dog is afraid of the trigger and afraid of you. The puppy book said no yelling, no hitting, no spray bottles, no shock collars. The same rule holds here, and it matters more, because a reactive dog is already living at the edge of what they can handle.

Retractable leash. No. Same reason as the puppy book. A retractable leash is always a little bit tight, so the dog never learns what a loose leash feels like, and a tight leash makes a reactive dog feel trapped. Use the six-foot leash from the puppy book for walks, and the long line for open space. That's it.

DO THIS TODAY

Check your harness fit. Two fingers under every strap. If it slides sideways or rubs, adjust it or replace it. A harness that fits wrong is worse than no harness at all.

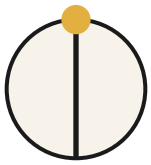
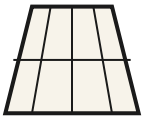


Peanut butter inside
let the dog lick it out

Dog puts nose in
on their own, a few seconds

Straps on
short sessions, never forced

Muzzle conditioning: slow, with food, never forced.

Front-clip harness	Long line	Basket muzzle
 clip here	 15–30 ft, open space only	 can pant, drink, take treats
Ring on the chest, so a pull turns the dog sideways.	Room to move and choose, where there are no triggers.	A safety tool, not a punishment. Condition it slowly.

Gear that helps: front-clip harness, long line, basket muzzle.

Chapter 7: What Not to Do

This is the shortest chapter in the book and the most important one to read twice. Every item in it is something owners do with the best intentions, and every item makes reactivity worse. If you recognize yourself in this chapter, don't feel bad. Most owners do one or two of these before they know better. The fix is simple: stop.

Don't punish the reaction. Yelling, yanking the leash, popping the collar, squirting water, any of it. Punishment doesn't teach a scared dog to feel safe. It teaches them that the scary thing brings pain, which makes the scary thing scarier. It also teaches them to hide the warning signs. A dog who gets punished for growling stops growling, and a dog who stops growling goes straight to biting without a warning. You want the warning. Never punish it.

Don't flood the dog. Flooding means forcing the dog to face their fear up close, on the theory that they'll get used to it. They won't. A scared dog forced into a crowd of dogs doesn't learn that dogs are safe. They learn that nobody will protect them, and the fear gets bigger. This is the same rule from the puppy book: never drag a scared puppy toward the thing they're afraid of. It was true at eight weeks old and it's true now.

Don't force greetings. "Just let them meet and sort it out" is the worst advice a reactive dog owner can get. Two dogs on leash who are forced to greet can't walk away when they've had enough, and a dog who can't walk away has nowhere to go. Chapter three said no greetings for now. This chapter says why: forced greetings are how reactive dogs get worse and how bites happen.

Don't use the dog park as training. The dog park is not socialization and it's not training. It's a chaotic yard full of unknown dogs, and a reactive dog in that yard is a dog who is over threshold from the moment they walk in. A dog who needs to learn that

other dogs are safe does not learn it in a crowd. They learn it one dog at a time, at a distance, in a session you planned.

Don't buy the dominance story. The alpha roll, the scruff grab, the "you have to be the pack leader" talk. It's old advice and it's wrong, and the puppy book said to walk out on any trainer who sells it. For a reactive dog it's worse than wrong, because it tells you the problem is that your dog doesn't respect you, when the problem is that your dog is scared. A scared dog doesn't need a boss. They need a teacher, and they need one who uses food and patience.

> **DO THIS TODAY**
>
> Pick one thing in this chapter you've been doing, and stop it. Just one. That's the whole assignment, and it's the highest-value thing in this book.

Chapter 8: Reading Your Dog Before the Reaction

Reactions don't come out of nowhere. They have a run-up, and if you learn to see it, you get a head start. Most owners only notice the barking and lunging, because that's the loud part. The useful part is the ten seconds before it, when the dog is telling you exactly what's about to happen.

The early signs. Yawning when the dog isn't tired. Licking their lips when there's no food around. Turning their head away. Ears going back. Moving slowly, or freezing for a second. These are the small signals, and they mean "I'm not comfortable." Most owners miss them, because they look like nothing. They aren't nothing. They're the dog's first try at telling you, and if you respond to them, the dog doesn't have to try louder.

The middle signs. The body goes stiff. The mouth closes. The stare locks on. The tail goes high and still, or tucks tight. The hackles go up along the shoulders and back. Hackles don't always mean aggression. They mean arousal, the body getting ready for something. A dog with their hackles up is a dog whose system is already running hot, and that's your cue to add distance now, not in a minute.

The late signs. Growling. Barking. Lunging. Snapping. This is the dog shouting, because the quiet signals didn't work. The growl is information, not defiance. A dog who growls is a dog who is still warning you, and a warning is a gift. Never punish the growl. A dog who learns that growling gets them punished stops growling, and then the next thing you get is a bite with no warning at all.

EARLY — asking quietly	MIDDLE — getting loud	LATE — shouting
Yawning when not tired Licking lips, no food around Turning the head away Ears back Moving slowly, or freezing	Body goes stiff Mouth closes Hard stare locks on Tail high and still, or tucked tight Hackles up	Growling Barking Lunging Snapping **The growl is information — never punish it.**
Calm looks like: soft body, loose tail, open mouth — and the treat test: a calm dog takes a treat and eats it.		

Read the run-up: early signals, middle signals, late signals.

Read the whole dog, not one signal. One signal by itself doesn't tell you much. A yawn could be tiredness. A tucked tail could be cold. But a stiff body plus a hard stare plus a closed mouth is a dog who is about to react, and you should believe all three together. The more signals you see at once, the closer the dog is to the edge.

Your dog's personal tells. Every dog has their own early signal, and it's usually something small that only their owner would notice. One dog yawns. Another licks their lips. Another goes quiet and stops sniffing. Another's ears go back a half inch. The signal is personal, and the only way to learn it is to watch. Spend one walk doing nothing but watching. Don't train, don't manage, just watch. Write down the first thing your dog does when a trigger appears in the distance. That's their tell, and it's the earliest warning you'll ever get.

A dog whose owner responds to a yawn never has to bark. That's the whole point of this chapter. The earlier you see it, the less there is to fix. The tell changes as the dog gets better, too. A dog who used to stiffen and stare might start looking at you instead, and that look is the new tell. It means the training is working. Write that down too. The log in the appendix has room for notes, and that's what the notes are for.

What calm looks like. A soft body. A loose tail that moves. An open mouth, maybe panting a little. Ears in their normal spot. And the treat test from chapter two: a calm dog takes a treat and eats it. If your dog won't take a treat, they're not calm, no matter

how quiet they're being. Quiet and calm are not the same thing. A dog can be silent and terrified.

DO THIS TODAY

Watch your dog for five minutes on a walk and write down three signals you saw before any reaction. Yawn, lip lick, stiffening, staring, whatever it was. Three signals. That's your dog's warning system, and now you know what it looks like.

Chapter 9: When to Call a Professional

Most reactive dogs get better with the work in this book. Some need more help, and knowing which group your dog is in matters. This chapter is the line. If your dog is on one side of it, keep working. If they're on the other, call someone today.

Call now if any of these fit. Your dog has bitten someone, or tried to bite. You feel unsafe walking your own dog. Your dog hurts themselves trying to get to a trigger, or panics so hard they can't recover for hours. You've worked the plan in this book steadily for a month and nothing has changed. Or your dog also guards food, toys, or people, and growls or snaps when you come near. Any one of those is a call-a-professional situation. Not next month. Today.

Vet behaviorist or trainer, and what's the difference. A vet behaviorist is a veterinarian who did extra years of training in behavior and passed a board exam. They can diagnose, they can prescribe medication, and they handle the hard cases: dogs with bite histories, dogs whose anxiety training alone can't touch, dogs whose reactivity has a medical cause. A certified trainer teaches skills. They run the sessions, coach you, and spot the mistakes you can't see. The letters to look for are CPDT-KA and KPA CTP, and both of them mean the trainer passed an exam and works without pain or fear.

Sometimes you need both: the behaviorist figures out what's going on and whether medication would help, and the trainer does the weekly work. If you can only afford one, start with the trainer, unless your dog has bitten someone. A bite history goes to the behaviorist first.

Medication is a tool, not a failure. A lot of owners hear "medication" and hear "my dog is broken" or "I've failed." Neither one is true. A daily anti-anxiety medication lowers the dog's baseline stress so the training can actually work. It's not sedation. Your

dog won't be drugged or dull. They'll be the same dog, just with a little more room between the trigger and the reaction, and that room is where learning happens. Only a vet prescribes it, and they decide if it's right for your dog. If they suggest it, it's worth trying. The dogs who do best on medication are usually the ones whose owners waited the longest to ask about it.

What a good trainer looks like. They use food and patience. They explain the plan before they start. They let you watch every session. They have credentials you can check. And they never reach for pain or fear first. If a trainer's first move with a reactive dog is a prong collar or a shock collar, that's not a trainer. That's someone selling you the problem.

Red flags. Guarantees. Talk about dominance, alpha rolls, or being the pack leader. A trainer who won't let you watch. A trainer who says your dog needs to be "put in their place." Any of those is a reason to walk out. The right trainer will feel like a teacher, not a drill sergeant, and your dog should be calmer at the end of a session, not more afraid.

What the first appointment looks like. The behaviorist or trainer will ask you to describe the problem, and then they'll watch your dog. They'll watch how your dog behaves, maybe walk them past a trigger at a distance. They'll ask about the dog's history, their health, and what you've already tried. Bring your log. A month of notes tells a trainer more in ten minutes than starting from nothing. The first appointment is mostly talking and watching. The plan comes after, written down, with steps and a schedule.

DO THIS TODAY

If anything in the "call now" list fits your dog, make the call today. Look up a vet behaviorist or a certified trainer in your area and book the first appointment. If nothing in that list fits, keep this chapter marked. You'll know if you need it later.

Chapter 10: The Four-Week Plan

Here's the whole book in four weeks. It's a plan, not a promise. Some dogs move faster. Some move slower. The weeks are the shape, not the deadline. If a week takes two weeks, that's fine. The plan still works.

Week one: management only. No training sessions yet. Your job this week is to stop the rehearsals. Find the threshold distance from chapter two and write it in the log. Pick your quiet routes and your quiet hours. Practice the U-turn at home until it's boring. Block the window view. Put the "no greetings" rule in place and tell anyone who walks your dog about it. Log every walk: where you went, what you saw, how close it was, how your dog did. By the end of the week you should have a baseline and a routine that produces zero or one reaction a day. That's the foundation everything else sits on.

Week two: start training. Three short sessions, five minutes each, at the distance where your dog can succeed. Trigger appears, treat, trigger goes away, treats stop. Teach Look At That at home with a boring object. Keep the managed walks going. Keep logging. If a session goes badly, add distance and try again tomorrow. At the end of the week, look at the log. You should see the first small change: your dog noticing a trigger and looking at you, even once. That's the win.

Week three: add the games. Take Look At That onto the walk, at a safe distance. Try scatter feeding when a trigger appears far away. If you need a muzzle, start conditioning it this week, a few minutes a day with peanut butter. If week two went well, move a few feet closer in your sessions. Only a few. If week two was rough, stay where you are. There is no prize for moving fast. There is a prize for moving at the dog's pace, and the prize is a dog who trusts the work.

Week four: put it together. Short walks with a plan. One trigger at a time. Use the U-turn when you need an exit, the games when you have distance, and the treat test to check where your dog is. Keep logging. By now you should see the shape of the progress: smaller reactions, faster recovery, more distance tolerated, a dog who checks in with you before exploding. That's not a cure. That's progress, and it's the kind that lasts, because it was built slowly.

When it falls apart. It will, at least once. A bad day, a surprise trigger around a corner, a walk that goes wrong from the first minute. When it happens, do three things. Add distance. End the session on a win, even a small one. And take a rest day tomorrow, a short boring walk, no training. Then go back a week in the plan and start from there. Falling back is not failing. It's how the work holds together.

What progress actually looks like. Not a dog who loves other dogs. Most reactive dogs never become social butterflies, and that's fine. Progress looks like this: the barking starts later and ends sooner. Your dog recovers in a minute instead of an hour. They look at you before they explode. They walk past a dog across the street without a scene. They take a treat in a place where they couldn't take one last month. Any one of those is real progress, and all of them together is a different dog.

After week four. Keep going. Same structure, same pace, same log. The big changes take months, not weeks, and that's normal. A dog who was terrified of strangers for a year doesn't stop being afraid in a month. But a dog who spent four weeks learning that triggers predict treats, and that you will keep them safe, is a dog on the way. Keep showing up. The puppy book ended the same way, because it's the same truth: the dog you want to live with is built one day at a time.

The second month. Keep the same structure. Same sessions, same log, same managed walks. The change in the second month is the distance: you'll find you can work a little

closer than you could in week one, and the recovery time keeps falling. This is also the month to add one new thing. A new walking route, a new training spot, a second helper dog. One new thing at a time, so if something goes wrong you know what caused it. If the second month feels boring, that's good. Boring means the dog is coping, and coping is the goal.

The second month is also when most owners quit, because the fast gains of the first month slow down. The first month is full of visible change. The second month is quiet work. Keep the log going, because the log is what proves the quiet work is working. A dog who took an hour to recover in week one and takes ten minutes in week six has made real progress, even if the walk looks the same from the outside.

DO THIS TODAY

Start week one today, even if today is Tuesday. Pick the route, practice the U-turn, open the log. The plan doesn't care what day it is. It only cares that you started.

Appendix

Threshold Log

Copy this grid for each week. Mark the date, the trigger, the distance in feet or blocks, the reaction on a scale of 0 to 3, how long it took your dog to settle, and one note. The pattern shows up in a week if you keep it up.

0 means your dog noticed and stayed calm. 1 means stiffening, staring, or a hard look, but no noise. 2 means barking or lunging once or twice, then settling. 3 means a full reaction that took minutes to come down from.

Date	Trigger	Distance	Reaction (0-3)	Recovery time	Notes

Read it at the end of each week. If the distance is shrinking and the recovery time is falling, the work is paying off. If the numbers stall for two weeks, change one thing: more distance, quieter routes, or a rest day after every training day. Don't change three things at once, or you won't know which one helped.

Weekly Training-Plan Template

Photocopy this page. Fill it in on Sunday night for the week ahead. One session a day is plenty. Two is the most. The rest of the week is managed walks and rest.

Day	Session (what + where)	Distance	Game or protocol	Notes
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

When It Goes Wrong on a Walk

Tear this out and keep it in your pocket for the first month. Five steps, in order.

1. Add distance. Cross the street, step behind a car, turn around. Distance first.
2. Scatter treats in the grass. Nose down buys you calm.
3. Say "this way" and U-turn. Walk away from the trigger.
4. Go home. A walk that went wrong is over. Don't try to fix it by walking past the trigger again.
5. Tomorrow is a rest day. Short walk, boring route, no training. Let the stress hormones clear.

One Last Thing

A month from now, your dog will be a different dog than the one who started this book. Not a perfect dog. Not a dog who loves everyone. A dog who trusts you to keep them safe, who looks at you before they explode, and who recovers faster than they used to. That trust is the whole book, really. Everything else is just how you earn it, one walk at a time.

Go take the dog outside. Keep the distance generous. And when they look at you, give them the treat. They earned it.

The Reactive Dog Guide

Help for the Dog Who Barks, Lunges, and Loses It on Walks

You know the walk. Your dog spots another dog and loses it — barking, lunging, dragging you down the sidewalk. You dread the walk instead of enjoying it. This guide shows you how to change that: find the distance where your dog can still learn, teach calm with games that work, and follow a four-week plan you can do on your own walks. Four weeks from now, you'll walk past another dog and your dog will keep it together. That's the walk you wanted when you brought them home.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- Find your dog's threshold — the distance where learning still happens
- Desensitization and counter-conditioning, step by step
- Games that teach calm: Look At That, scatter feeding, 1-2-3, settle mat
- Gear that helps — and the gear to leave in the drawer
- The four-week plan, day by day

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